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Python: The User Friendly Language for Coding



This article will delight newbies who want to get a foothold in the programming world. It introduces readers to the fascinating world of Python, which is a very versatile programming language.

Computers, today, come with immense disk space, multi-core processors and high speed Internet connectivity. And they use computer languages that interact with the operating system and execute processes at a high speed. One such language is Python, which is used as a high level programming language. It was first released in 1991 by Guido van Rossum, an ex-employee of Google. It is quite easy to learn, as it uses English keywords frequently, unlike the heavy syntaxes of other languages. Moreover, programmers can code the logic using fewer lines of code than what is required in other programming languages like C or Java. The unique design, notably, using white space indentation to delimit code blocks, makes Python more readable and clean.

Python is an interpreted, interactive and object-oriented scripting language. The Python code is processed by the processor at run time, i.e., it does not need to be compiled as in Java, which is compiled to get the *.class* file. The term interactive implies that you can use the Python prompt to write the code, which interacts with the interpreter, and by encapsulating the code within objects, it follows the OOPS principle. The other features that make Python cool are that it is extendable, i.e., it can run on a wide range

of hardware with the same user interface; it is scalable, supporting very large programs; and it has user interfaces for UNIX, Windows and Mac. It also has efficient high-level data structures and extensive standards-free libraries, which make programming easy; hence, it is considered the language for beginners.

In this article, we will learn how to install, set up and use Python. The cool thing about learning Python is that there are no prerequisites. Even if you are a novice to programming you can become a pro coder within a month. To start with, download and install Python from <https://www.python.org/downloads/release/python-2712/>. For this article, we are using Python 2.7. The above link also contains Python for Windows and Mac. On most Linux boxes, Python is pre-installed. For Windows, download Python and run the *.msi* file. Upon completion, add the environment variable named 'PYTHON' and its value as the directory where Python is (in this case, 'C:\Python27'), as shown in Figure 1. We can verify whether Python has been installed correctly by running the *python -version* command in the command line. This will give you the current version of Python running on your computer, as shown in Figure 2. To create Python files, use any text editor of your choice. For this article, we will be using the Sublime